

apps. Since extracting the .apk file (the file with which one installs an app) is a trivial affair, many paid apps can be obtained for free with virtually no effort. This obviously acts as a deterrent to developers who see much smaller earnings from their Android apps than their iOS counterparts. Market research companies have also noted that Android users are far less willing to pay for apps than iPhone users, and developers are forced to release free but ad-supported versions of apps.

Possibly the biggest gripe with the Android platform is that the market is too 'fragmented'. Fragmentation can be due to the near infinite variety of devices, each differing in screen size and hardware specs, or in terms of the version of Android they're running. This limits app compatibility for developers, and there is no guarantee that an app published to the Google Play Store will work on every single Android device out there. Many may face compatibility issues due to inferior hardware or smaller or lower resolution screens. OEMs and carriers who wish to differentiate their products from the vast expanse of Android handsets try to skin the OS with a custom interface such as HTC's Sense or Samsung's TouchWiz. While these skins add additional functionality to the OS, updating these skins when a new version of Android is released can take a significant amount of time and many users are left using an outdated version of the OS.

Another cause for fragmentation has been offshoots from the original Android project such as the Amazon Kindle Fire and the Barnes and Noble Nook, both runaway successes, which only serve to worsen this condition. Both use a highly customized version of Android with their own app store for downloading modified versions of Android apps, and are incompatible with the original Google Play Store. The Amazon Kindle Fire has been a runaway success with a greater share of the tablet market than conventional Android tablets, and hasn't shown any signs of slowing down. Such products require developers to submit apps to multiple online stores, often with different rules and revenue schemes. It's also the one factor where Apple has a clear advantage, for Apple exercises complete control over the hardware and software that goes into its products, along with strict regulation for apps that enter their App Store.

In reply to this criticism, several developers have stated that Android fragmentation is not an issue, but a feature of the ecosystem, and a very important one at that. The issue of screen sizes can be tackled fairly easily as the Android SDK allows programmers to provide different graphics for different resolutions, with an emulator that can emulate nearly any